A major issue driving this wedge was dyarchy. The British implemented this concept because of the realization that the colony could not be governable in the long term. The British in India officially introduced dyarchy in 1919. Because Burma was part of the colony, several executive council positions were reserved for the Burmese. Dyarchy introduced some of the concepts of democracy to the colony, including enfranchisement of all adults aged 18 and older, including women. This was a liberal concept for the time.

EMERGENCE OF BURMESE NATIONALISM

Several issues connected to World War I helped to intensify nationalism within Burma. Shipping shortages disrupted the rice-export trade causing unrest within the population. Furthermore, several poor growing seasons also exacerbated the tension within Burma. In addition, Burmese citizens were angered by tax assessments that they did not comprehend. These economic issues in turn caused social and political unrest.

A political turning point for Burma as well as for the entire developing world was President Woodrow Wilson's statement concerning self-determination for the colonized populations globally. This coupled with the growing trends in India toward nationalism helped to spark a political awakening within Burma. Indigenous products were driven out of the market and local manufacturers were eventually out of business. The traditional economic structure was either diminished or lost entirely. The Indian model provided structure and procedures for the Burmese nationalists to follow.

The starting point for the nationalist movement in 20th-century Burma was an incident during 1916–1917 concerning the prohibition of the wearing of shoes on pagoda premises. A lawyer and YMBA member by the name of U Thein Maung found a sign at the Shwe Sandaw pagoda that read, “No one permitted to wear shoes in this pagoda but Englishmen and Asiatic Europeans.” The fact that European visitors to pagodas generally did not remove their shoes was sacrilegious behavior in the eyes of many Burmese Buddhists. This belief was rooted in ritual practices of traditional, cosmological Buddhism. This action was considered desecration of sacred space. The sign was replaced with one stating that footwear was banned for